

UNDERSTANDING GENDER AS A SOCIAL CONSTRUCT

INTRODUCTION TO GENDER STUDIES



OBJECTIVES

1. Develop a comprehensive understanding of the social construction of gender and its impact on individuals and societies, including the ability to critically analyze the intersections of gender with other social categories such as race, class, and sexuality.
2. Explore key theories and concepts within Gender Studies, including feminist theory, queer theory, and intersectionality, in order to analyze and articulate the complexities of gender dynamics in diverse cultural and societal contexts.



OBJECTIVES

3. Cultivate critical thinking skills to evaluate historical and contemporary issues related to gender, and to apply this knowledge to contribute to positive social change and advocate for gender equality and justice.



CONTENTS

1. Defining Gender

2. Historical Perspective on Gender

3. The Social Construction of Gender





Gender

As a Social Construct



➤ “Gender is so pervasive in our society that we assume it is bred in our genes...gender is constantly created and re-created out of human interaction, out of social life and is the texture and order of that social life”



Sex/Gender

- Sex: categorisation of people into male and female groups based on biological characteristics
- Gender: socio-cultural interpretation of sex (expected behavioural pattern of being a socially appropriate man or woman); masculinity and femininity
- “Physiological sex” and “social gender”
- Ann Oakley’s *Sex, Gender and Society* (1972)



Differences Between Gender and Sex

GENDER	SEX
•Socially created ideas and practices of what it is considered to be female or male. •The social roles and relationships between men and women, they are context-specific and can change according to circumstances, and from generation to generation. •Gender is influenced by other factors as wealth, class, age, education, race, ethnicity, religion and ideology •Gender is imposed by human society, which generates some deep and far-reaching sense of inequality between the sexes	•Universal, biological differences between men and women •Characteristics that categorize someone as either female or male • Biological sex differences are very few and are unimportant in terms of determining gender inequality. •sex is a basic fact of nature and does not unfairly assign its biological roles



Gender Identity

- Identity as reflexive self-relation (Butler, 2004; de Beauvoir, 1953, 74)
- Physical embodiment, people's relative location within their social environment and how they are judged by others
- Ultimately how people view themselves with respect to gender
- Human need to “sort” individuals according to the two gender system (dyadic gender model)



- Reinforcing of gender order
- Combined influence of internal feelings and social pressures guides gender identity development, impacting how individuals feel as gendered persons and constraining their behaviour based on what they think and experience as acceptable for their given gender



- **Masculinity:** a socially constructed component of gender that is typically associated with men and male characteristics (behaviours and practices);
- Hegemonic Masculinity (strength, aggression, courage, independence and virility); often associated with heterosexual, white, middle class status in Western cultures (Noble, 2004; Schippers, 2007)
- High expectations (work responsibilities, finances, family obligations), effects on health-“risky” health behaviours; being tough, drinking behaviours of young men
- Masculinity as a “floating signifier”-because it is not stagnant and must be constantly maintained and reproduced through various gendered practices and behaviour; given meaning by human-constructed language and the bodies that reproduce it (schippers, 2007)



- **FEMININITY:** associated with femaleness, constructed and reproduced through individuals' practices and behaviours in their daily lives
- “Emphasised femininity” (not hegemonic femininity) (concept discussed by Connell & Messerschmidt, 2005; Schippers, 2007)
- “Emphasised femininity” as a prioritised form of femininity, characterised by its domination by masculinity, which is a crucial component in men's supremacy over women in the gender order
- In this way, all femininities are constructed as subordinate to masculinities (hegemonic masculinity); through this subordination gender hegemony is created and maintained



- While masculinity is prioritised as the “gold standard”, both masculinity and femininity are constructed through their differences to each other
- Femininity-health impacts-encouraging feminine individuals to prioritise the health of children and other family members above their own, as part of a nurturing and caring ideals
- Positioning of femininity as “other”, distinctly different from masculinity as opposed to a function of the gender system in its own right, both within society and reproduced in gender theorising and research



Gender Stereotypes



- Gender stereotypes-one sided and exaggerated images of men and women which are deployed repeatedly in everyday lives
- Child socialisation into sex roles-children literature, toys and games
- Adults and children are denied opportunities



- Gender stereotypes-personal traits, behaviours, occupations, hobbies, appearance, family functions, communication, sports activities and preferences
- It shapes people's behaviours, expectations and roles; roles can become stereotypes
- Stereotyping as a normal cognitive process-as a categorisation-stereotypes of men and women-role of religion and culture
- Challenging gender stereotypes-"Take Our Daughters to Work"- replacing gendered terms with gender neutral terms (mailman-mail carrier/ chairman-chair)-roles of parents



Gender Discrimination

- Discrimination-the unjust or prejudicial treatment of different categories of people, especially on the ground of race, age or sex
- How this prejudice develop? Engrained in social structure? Nonvisible?
- In the form of women health and child malnutrition
- Universality of gender discrimination-public and domestic domain-patriarchal ideology produced specific rules, roles and regulations-"The second sex"-link with subordination



Gender Division of Labour

- It is the consequence of how a particular society divides work among men and women according to what is considered appropriate to each gender
- Material discussion



Heteronormativity

- Micheal Warner first coined this term to refer to the overwhelming power of the assumption that heterosexuality is natural and normal and is the norm to be emulated- grew out of queer theory
- Heterosexuality is taken for granted and is universalised
- Regarded as the norm and moral way to be and carries with it such pressures that some non heterosexuals may not feel comfortable publicly acknowledging their sexual preference
- Societal expectations or standards are reinforced with rules and structures
- Rules may take the form of formal (with the enactment of laws) or may be informal (social norms) that exist to maintain heterosexual privilege, or heterosexism



- Heteronormative laws - validate only heterosexual relations, criminalisation of homosexuality, the creation of a parallel institution for marriage, civil unions, to protect the privileges of marriage for the union of a man and a woman and sodomy laws
- Heterosexuality as the norm and any other form of sexual desire, expression or relationship is 'abnormal' or 'wrong'
- Abstract concept
- French feminist Monique Wittig, "the category of sex is a political category that found society as heterosexual"



Colonial Modernity and the Production of Heteronormativity

- Criminalisation of same-sex activity is not an ancient Indian tradition
- Ruth Vanita and Saleem Kidwai - *Same Sex Love in India* - traces writings in Indian languages about love between women and love between men who are not biologically related
- The Persian aesthetic traditions prior to the European encounter considered the male body and the love of men for men as beautiful (Najmabadi, 2005)
- British Colonial govt introduced this legal provision in the nineteenth century (Nivedita Menon, pg.95) {in 1861 as section 377 of Indian Penal Code}
- “*Voluntary carnal intercourse against the order of nature, with any man, woman or animal*”
- Victorian notions of proper sexual relationships which delegitimised everything but the heterosexual, patriarchal, monogamous family unit
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- It structures institutions like marriage and produces a set of ideals and ideas about how sexuality should be organised
- Particular understandings of sexuality and gender get to be embedded in and woven through the very fabric of our institutions and everyday lives in ways that are powerful, discriminatory and exclusionary
- A heteronormative culture establishes the coherence and validity of social order in order to perpetuate the norm of heterosexuality



Gender Continuum and LGBTIQ

- The variations people experience biologically, feel emotionally and express outwardly with respect to gender, gender identity and sexual orientation
- Umbrella concept
- Gender identities that transcend the two traditional classes of male and female
- A collection of gender defining characteristics that vary by minute degrees
- Accounts for the presence of multiple variations and combinations of gender and even includes a genderless variant
- THE AUTHENTIC DIVERSITY OF HUMAN GENDERS



- Seeing gender identity on a continuum
- Some people could be born male but feel female and vice versa
- LGBTIQ (Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Intersex, Queer)





LESBIAN: a woman who is primarily attracted to other women

GAY-a person who is primarily attracted to members of the same sex. Although it can be used for any sex (for example: gay man, gay woman, gay person) lesbian is sometimes the preferred term for women who are attracted to women. It is preferable to homosexual.





TRANSGENDER: a person does not identify with the biological sex they assigned at birth

BISEXUAL: attraction to both men and women as sexual partners

INTERSEX-Persons who possess both male and female reproductive organs in a variety of combinations





QUEER: an umbrella term sometimes used by LGBTI people to refer to the entire LGBTI community; queer is an in-group term, and a word that can be considered offensive to some people, depending on their generation, geographic location, and relationship to the word (because of its historically derogatory use)



- One sex model-woman's unopened genitalia
- Role of Chromosomes and hormones
- XX-female & XY-male
- Different stages of development
- Testis (testosterone) or ovary (oestrogen and progesterone)
- Brain sex-the development of potentialities
- Pubertal hormonal sex
- But there are variations like XXY,XXYY etc



Table 1. Terms Essential to Understand Gender Continuum.

Term	Definition
Agender	An individual who does not identify with any gender ^a
Androgyny	A term meaning “having the characteristics or nature of both male and female” ^b
Cisgender	A person who identifies as the same gender to which they were assigned at birth ^a
Gender Creative	A term used to describe individuals, generally children and young adults, who creatively define gender in their own terms based on how they feel on the inside and how they look on the outside ^c
Gender Dysphoria	Is a term used to describe the internal conflict experienced when a person does not identify as the sex assigned at birth ^d
Gender-Fluid	An individual who identify as a mixture of both male and female ^e
Gender Liminal	An individual who is in transition, does not entirely identify what they were or what they eventually will be ^f
Genderqueer	An individual who does not identify as exclusively male or female ^g
Intersex	Persons who possess both male and female reproductive organs in a variety of combinations ^h
Transgender	Individuals who identify as a gender other than that assigned to them at birth ⁱ
Two-Spirited	“A person who identifies as having both masculine and feminine spirit” ^j

^aGenderSpectrum (2018). ^bAndrogyny (2018, para. 1). ^cSirois (2018). ^dGender dysphoria (2018). ^eGender-fluid (2018). ^fGender Liminal (2018).

^gGenderqueer (2018). ^hIntersexuality (2018). ⁱTransgender (2018). ^jRe:searching for LGBTQ Health (2018, para 1).



Social Institutions and Gender Reproduction

- Institution-as those parts of social life that are complex, ongoing and organised
- Important source of cultural beliefs about the social world, including beliefs about gender
- Institutions provide scripts for actions
- Regular and permanent that they often accepted as just “the way things are”; self perpetuating; rarely challenged and scrutinised
- Because they are taken for granted, they produce shared account of their existence and purpose



- Gender is not something individual possess, rather, an aspect of social organisation
- Institutional perspectives focus on gender as aspects of social structure and culture
- roles, positions, and expectations for individuals
- **Gendered Institutions:** “rules of the game”
- According to Acker (1992) institutions constitute and embody aspects of gender. To say that an institution is gendered means



“that gender is present in the processes, practices, images and ideologies and distributions of power in the various sectors of social life. Taken as more or less functioning wholes, the institutional structures of the societies are organised along the lines of gender... these institutions have been historically developed by men, currently dominated by men, and symbolically interpreted from the stand point of men in leading positions, both in the present and historically”



- Aspects of social life which are treated as gender neutral or genderless in fact are expressions of gender
- organisation, structure, and practices of social institutions
- Entrenched, powerful and taken-for-granted aspects of the social order produce and reproduce gender distinctions and inequalities
- Eg. sports (differential opportunities and resources for each gender to be involved in sport; ideas about male and female bodies and their capabilities)
- Discuss work and family as gendered institutions

Ref. Amy S Wharton, The Sociology of Gender; Pg.87



Patriarchy as an Ideology and Practice

- Literally meaning- rule of father or ‘patriarch’
- Patriarch-a societal elder, has legitimate power over others in the social unit
- Acc 2 Feminist writers-social system of masculine domination over women-power relation in both public and private spheres
- The concept help us to understand women’s realities



- According to Sylvia Walby, “patriarchy is a system of social structures and practices in which men dominate, oppress and exploit women” (1990:20)
- According to Lerner, Patriarchy is the manifestation and institutionalisation of male dominance over women and children in the family and the extension of male dominance over women in society in general. It implies that “men hold power in all the important institutions of society” and that “women are deprived of access to such power”. However, it does not imply that “women are either totally powerless or totally deprived of rights, influence, and resources”



Origins of Patriarchy

- Traditionalist- men are born to dominate and women to be subordinate; hierarchy always existed and will continue; as rule of nature it cannot be changed
- Aristotle- female was mutilated male (someone who doesn't have a soul); biological inferiority of woman makes her unable to reason, make decisions etc
- Sigmund Freud- normal human was male (women's biology determines their psychology)
- These theories never had any scientific or historical evidence



- Patriarchy is manmade; historical processes have created it
- Frederick Engels (1884) “The Origins of the Family, Private Property and the State”
- Acc 2 him, women’s subordination began with the development of **private property**, when the world historical defeat of the female sex took place. He says both the division of classes and the subordination of women developed historically.
- To ensure inheritance, mother-right was overthrown
- In order to establish the right of the father, women had to be domesticated and confined and their sexuality regulated and controlled
- It was in this period, both patriarchy and monogamy for women were established



End

